

The Financial Separation Checklist

Work top to bottom. Windows in **red** are hard deadlines set by law or regulation; the rest are strong recommendations where earlier is better. Timelines current as of July 2026 and subject to change; confirm specifics with the VA, DFAS, or your transition office.

PHASE ONE · AS SOON AS YOUR SEPARATION DATE IS SET

- ☐ **Build the income-gap reserve.** Cash sized to the realistic gap between your last military paycheck and your first full civilian one. 6+ months out
Start now; it takes months.
- ☐ **File your VA disability claim through BDD.** Fresh records, reachable providers, decision near your date. Missed the window? 180-90 days before
File standard after separation.
- ☐ **Run terminal leave vs. selling leave, both ways.** Terminal keeps pay, allowances, and benefits running; selling pays base before out-processing
pay only, taxable.

PHASE TWO · THE FINAL WEEKS AND OUT-PROCESSING

- ☐ **Line up your TRICARE bridge.** Confirm TAMP eligibility (about 180 days premium-free if you qualify); otherwise price CHCBP (premium-based, up to 18 months) against marketplace or employer coverage. confirm before your date
- ☐ **Update DEERS for every family member.** It drives the family's benefit eligibility, including transitional TRICARE. while personnel is close
- ☐ **Retirees: make the SBP election with the math in front of you.** One of the least reversible decisions in the transition; declining at retirement
generally requires notarized spouse concurrence.
- ☐ **Verify every field on your DD-214 before signing.** Then secure certified copies: one digital, one physical, consider the county recorder. at the table
- ☐ **Set your state tax and residency plan.** Active-duty residency protections end with your service; the answer should be ready effective day one
for day one.

PHASE THREE · AFTER SEPARATION, THE CLOCKS ARE RUNNING

- ☐ **Enroll in VA healthcare early.** Separate from your disability claim; establishes you in the system and builds the civilian-side first weeks after
medical record.
- ☐ **Convert SGLI before the clock runs out.** Free coverage continues about 120 days. Apply for VGLI within about 240 days of separation and you generally cannot be declined for health reasons. ~120 / ~240 days
- ☐ **Make the TSP decision on purpose.** Update beneficiaries and contact info with the TSP directly, now; then decide keep, roll, or beneficiaries now
split deliberately, not by drift.

The full version of every item, including the reasoning and the traps, lives at rosefinancialmanagement.com → Knowledge Base → Military Transition. Free, no email required.

THE ACRONYMS, DECODED

- BDD** · Benefits Delivery at Discharge: the VA program for filing your disability claim 180 to 90 days before separation.
- TAMP** · Transitional Assistance Management Program: about 180 days of premium-free TRICARE for qualifying separations.
- SBP** · Survivor Benefit Plan: the retirement election that continues part of retired pay to your survivors.
- DEERS** · Defense Enrollment Eligibility Reporting System: the record that drives your family's benefit eligibility.
- DFAS** · Defense Finance and Accounting Service: the military pay office, for final pay and leave payouts.
- CHCBP** · Continued Health Care Benefit Program: premium-based coverage that can extend the bridge up to 18 months.
- SGLI / VGLI** · Servicemembers' / Veterans' Group Life Insurance: your in-service coverage and its post-service continuation.
- TSP** · Thrift Savings Plan: the federal retirement savings plan your contributions built.

This checklist is educational and general in nature. It is not individualized investment, tax, legal, or insurance advice, and program rules, timelines, and eligibility criteria change; confirm current specifics with the VA, DFAS, the TSP, your transition assistance office, and your own tax and legal advisors before acting. Kevin Rose is a Registered Representative with, and securities are offered through, LPL Financial, member FINRA/SIPC. Investment advice offered through Valley Wealth Strategies, a registered investment advisor and separate entity from LPL Financial.